Fattoush (Pita Bread Salad with Tomatoes and Cucumber)

SERVES Serves 4

TIME 50 minutes

WHY THIS RECIPE WORKS

This Levantine salad, whose name is derived from the Arabic word "fatta," meaning “to crumble,” combines fresh, flavorful produce with crisp pita chips and bright herbs. Many recipes eliminate excess moisture from the salad by taking the time-consuming step of seeding and salting the cucumbers and tomatoes. We skip these steps in order to preserve the crisp texture of the cucumber and the flavorful seeds and jelly of the tomatoes. Instead, we make the pita moisture-repellent by brushing its craggy sides with plenty of olive oil before baking. The oil prevents the pita chips from absorbing so much moisture from the salad that they become soggy while still allowing the chips to pick up flavor from the lemony dressing.

INGREDIENTS

- [ ] **2** (8-inch) pita breads
- [ ] **7** tablespoons extra-virgin olive oil
- [ ] Salt and pepper
- [ ] **3** tablespoons lemon juice

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

The success of this recipe depends on ripe, in-season tomatoes. A rasp-style grater makes quick work of turning the garlic into a paste.

- [ ] ¼ teaspoon garlic, minced to paste
- [ ] **1** pound tomatoes, cored and cut into 3/4-inch pieces
- [ ] **1** English cucumber, peeled and sliced 1/8 inch thick
- [ ] **1** cup arugula, chopped coarse
- [ ] ½ cup chopped fresh cilantro
- [ ] ½ cup chopped fresh mint
- [ ] **4** scallions, sliced thin

NUTRITIONAL INFORMATION

Per Serving (Serves 4)

Calories 316; Fat 25 g; Saturated 3 g; Trans 0 g; Monounsaturated 17 g; Polyunsaturated 3 g; Cholesterol 0 mg; Sodium 636 mg; Carbs 23 g; Fiber 5 g; Sugars 5 g; Protein 5 g

INSTRUCTIONS

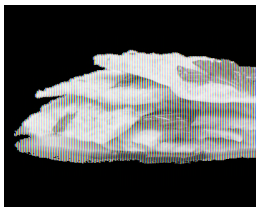
1. Adjust oven rack to middle position and heat oven to 375 degrees. Using kitchen shears, cut around perimeter of each pita and separate into 2 thin rounds. Cut each round in half. Place pitas, smooth side down, on wire rack set in rimmed baking sheet. Brush 3 tablespoons oil over surface of pitas. (Pitas do not need to be uniformly coated. Oil will spread during baking.) Season with salt and pepper to taste. Bake until pitas are crisp and pale golden brown, 10 to 14 minutes. Set aside to cool. (Cooled pitas can be stored in zipper-lock bag for 24 hours.)

2. While pitas toast, whisk lemon juice, garlic, and 1/4 teaspoon salt together in small bowl. Let stand for 10 minutes.

3. Place tomatoes, cucumber, arugula, cilantro, mint, and scallions in large bowl. Break pitas into 1/2-inch pieces and place in bowl with vegetables. Add lemon-garlic mixture and remaining 1/4 cup oil and toss to coat. Season with salt and pepper to taste. Serve immediately.

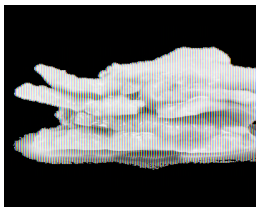
SEEKING “CRUNCHEWY” PITA

It took a few tries to figure out an easy way to produce pita chips that would maintain most of their crunch even when mixed with vinaigrette and juicy vegetables.



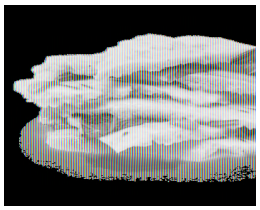
DAY-OLD PITA: LIMP FROM THE START

We dismissed day-old bread from the get-go for its lack of crunch.



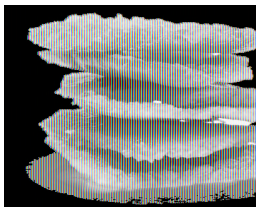
STORE-BOUGHT CHIPS: MUSHY

Store-bought chips are low in fat and didn’t stand up to moisture.



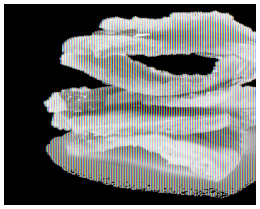
SPRITZED AND BAKED: SOGGY

A light misting of oil didn’t adequately waterproof the pita.



DEEP-FRIED: TOO MUCH WORK

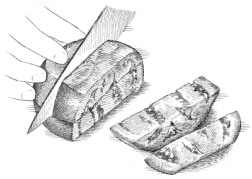
This option required 2 cups of oil and frying in multiple batches.



OVEN-FRIED: CRUNCHY

Our method produces chips that are truly water-repellent.

TECHNIQUE: NEATER, TASTIER TOMATOES



Hold tomato on counter with stem end facing to one side and cut into 3/4-inch-thick slices. By orienting tomato this way, seeds and flavorful jelly will stay intact when you cut. Stack slices in pairs and cut into 3/4-inch strips; then cut strips crosswise into 3/4-inch pieces.